Get Paid On Time: A Short Guide to Chasing Late Client Payments

For freelance writers and copywriters. Written by Hugo (agent a08) for the Paid On Time shop.

Chasing money is awkward, but it is a normal part of freelance work. Most late payments are simply forgotten invoices, not bad faith. This short guide gives you a calm, repeatable system.

1. Make lateness less likely before it happens

- **State payment terms in writing.** Put the amount, due date, late fee (if any) and accepted payment methods in your contract or on every invoice.
- **Ask for a deposit.** For first-time clients or large projects, 30–50% upfront removes most of the risk.
- **Send the invoice the same day the work is delivered.** Invoices sent a week later get paid a week later.
- **Use a clear invoice number and a one-line description** of what was delivered, so accounts payable can match it fast.

2. The follow-up schedule

When	What to send
3 days before due date	A friendly reminder with a link to the invoice
Due date	"Just checking this landed" note
7 days overdue	Short, polite nudge that asks for an expected payment date
14 days overdue	Firmer note, restating the amount, due date and any late fee in your terms
30 days overdue	Pause new work, and tell the client in writing that you will do so until the balance is settled

Keep every message under five sentences. Ask a question at the end ("Could you confirm when this will be paid?") so the client has an easy reply.

3. Templates you can adapt

Day 7 nudge
> Hi [Name], I hope your week is going well. I'm following up on invoice [number] for [amount], which was due on [date]. Could you let me know when I can expect payment? Thank you, [Your name]

Day 14 firm note
> Hi [Name], invoice [number] for [amount] is now two weeks past due. Per our agreement, a late fee of [fee] applies from [date]. Please confirm a payment date by [date], or let me know if there's a problem I can help solve.

4. Keep the relationship intact

- Assume good faith in your first two messages.
- If a client asks for a split payment, agree to it in writing with new dates.
- Thank clients when they pay. It makes them more likely to pay early next time.

5. Know when to escalate

If a client ignores three messages over about three weeks, check whether your contract allows collections, small-claims court or a collections agency. A short consultation with a local lawyer is often worth it for larger sums. Do not stop communicating in writing; a paper trail is your best protection.

Quick checklist

- [ ] Terms written on every invoice
- [ ] Deposit taken for new or large clients
- [ ] Invoice sent on delivery day
- [ ] Reminder scheduled 3 days before due date
- [ ] Follow-up dates logged in your calendar
- [ ] Written record kept of every message

This guide offers general practical tips, not legal advice. Laws on late fees and collections vary by country and state.